

Tony Jin

Dr. Plane

Modern World History 10A

May 22, 2026

North Korea's Nuclear Program: The [In]effectiveness of UN Sanctions

Since North Korea's first nuclear test in 2006, the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) has implemented several different sanctions to restrict the nation's nuclear and missile development. However, two decades later, these sanctions have clearly failed. North Korea has found ways to bypass these financial barriers and maintain connections worldwide (Iqbal). Even more alarmingly, the regime's state media revealed footage of Kim Jong-un reviewing what they claim is their first nuclear-powered submarine: a massive vessel designed to significantly boost their nuclear strike capabilities (Choe).

Meanwhile, innocent civilians are paying the costs of these failed policies. Economic restrictions severely disrupt the flow of essential aid, leaving 60,000 already malnourished North Korean children facing the immediate threat of starvation ("Humanitarian Impact"). On top of the humanitarian downsides, worldwide consensus has recently collapsed. Russia's recent veto at the UN is "the third step in a systematic effort to undermine the UN sanctions regime," dismantling the Panel of Experts monitoring North Korean sanctions and further threatening the UN's effectiveness (Cha and Kim). This paper will explore the historical roots of this crisis throughout the 20th and 21st centuries, examine the current state of North Korea's nuclear expansion along with its hidden humanitarian crisis, and evaluate the urgent challenges facing world leaders who must now change the ineffective strategy of endless sanctions.

The origins of the modern North Korean nuclear crisis are related to the unresolved geopolitical issues of the mid-twentieth century. After the end of World War II, the Korean peninsula was divided, eventually culminating in a brutal conflict in 1950. The Korean War ended in 1953 with an armistice but no fully official peace treaty, permanently splitting the peninsula into two opposing states in a standoff ("Korean War"). In this tense environment, North Korea began building nuclear infrastructure in the late 1950s with direct help from the Soviet Union ("Fact Sheet").

For decades, the program operated secretly and relatively unknown. It was not until 1992, when the International Atomic Agency (IAEA) finally began safeguards inspections, that the international community realized the extent of this threat. The inspectors quickly discovered data mismatches that strongly suggested the existence of hidden, undeclared plutonium, but North Korea outright refused to grant access to these suspicious waste sites ("Fact Sheet"). In an attempt to de-escalate the growing crisis, diplomatic efforts were launched in the 1990s. President Bill Clinton approved a landmark plan in 1994, arranging over \$4 billion in energy aid to North Korea over a decade. In exchange, Pyongyang committed to freezing and gradually dismantling its nuclear weapons development program ("Clinton Approves").

However, this diplomatic victory was very short-lived. By 1999, US advisors confirmed that North Korea was violating the 1994 agreement by secretly advancing its nuclear and long-range missile programs. American spy satellites captured undeniable evidence of the regime digging secret underground complexes deep into the hillsides ("Clinton Adviser"). This cycle of agreements followed by deception created a pattern of distrust that carried over and increased in the next century.

While entering the 21st century, North Korea used a focused, patient, and long-term strategy in order to try to solidify its status as a nuclear-armed state. On the other hand, the diplomatic response from the US was very inconsistent; they mostly reacted to crises as they happened instead of proactively managing the long-term threat (Hecker et al.). As North Korea conducted many different nuclear tests, the international community decided to default on a strategy of financial punishment. Since 2006, "the UN Security Council has passed nearly a dozen resolutions sanctioning North Korea for developing nuclear weapons and related activities," and the United States along with other countries have also "imposed unilateral sanctions" ("What to Know").

Unfortunately, the strategy of using financial ruin as a threat has failed to deter North Korea. The North Korean regime calculated the financial damage the sanctions would cause and decided that the cost was worth paying in order to secure a nuclear arsenal (Snyder). Furthermore, American leaders are ignoring the reality that UN sanctions lose their effectiveness over time. North Korea continuously gets better at bypassing them, and political divisions within the UN make it impossible to enforce them properly anymore (Klein-Ahlabrandt).

Even when alternative diplomatie methods were explored, they essentially yielded no results. There were highly publicized and historic summit meetings between Kim Jong-un and president Donald Trump in 2018 and 2019, but the diplomatic stalemate still remained. Recently, Kim Jong-un stated that future peace talks are only possible if the United States completely abandons its fundamental goal of stripping North Korea of its nuclear weapons ("Kim Jong-un Open"). This rigid stance he has taken defined the 21st-century background of the conflict, revealing that pure economic pressure cannot break a regime that is willing to isolate its entire population just for military supremacy.

Today, the situation on North Korea's nuclear policy shows a massive failure in international policy, with their thriving illegal economy, a broken global consensus, and a terrible humanitarian crisis. Having been pushed almost entirely out of the legal global economy, the North Korean regime was forced to adapt. It became highly skilled at operating black-market smuggling rings and vast unofficial cash networks in order to sustain its government and economy (Moon and Park). In the digital part, North Korea aggressively utilizes state-sponsored hackers and different financial institutions to steal and launder huge amounts of digital currency. It was reported that these North Korean hackers had successfully stolen an estimated \$3 billion over six years, funneling this illicit wealth straight into their weapons of mass destruction programs (Lederer, "Russian Veto"; Hussein).

Diplomatically, the situation has reached a dangerous point. For the first time since the sanctions began in 2006, the UN Security Council was fractured in 2022; China and Russia were actively blocking the United States from punishing North Korea for launching advanced ICBMs (Lederer, "China and Russia"). This trend of Russia supporting North Korea continued into early 2024, where Russia utilized its veto power to completely dissolve the international committee that had been responsible for monitoring, tracking, and investigating North Korean sanctions violations for 14 years (Lederer, "Russian Veto"). This international committee was the very UN monitoring panel that reported how North Korean hackers stole 3 billion dollars to fund their nuclear weapons program, highlighting the extent and impact of this broken global consensus (Lederer, "Russian veto"). Now, although North Korea is still open to diplomatic meetings, the regime has officially stated that they will never negotiate the dismantling of their nuclear weapons, regardless of any friendly relationships with foreign leaders ("North Korea Says Kim's Relations").

Even though the official UN monitoring panel investigating North Korean sanctions violations was disbanded, there is still a clear devastating humanitarian impact from the sanctions. In fact, medical and public health experts calculate that thousands of North Korean civilians have died directly as a result of the complex system of UN sanctions blocking or delaying necessary humanitarian interventions (Park et al.). Furthermore, a 2018 UNICEF report explained how "200,000 North Korean children already suffer from acute malnutrition, and sanctions put 60,000 of these vulnerable children at risk of starvation due to the disruption in the availability of humanitarian supplies" caused by the tightening sanctions ("Humanitarian Impact"). North Korea is working hard to illegally bypass these restrictions created by the UN, funneling the money straight into their nuclear weapons program, but leaving innocent civilians in a humanitarian crisis, unable to receive bare minimum supplies.

Moving forward, the greatest challenge facing world leaders is the fractured UNSC. Russia and China are now actively shielding Pyongyang from further penalties, so the international community can no longer rely on a unified global front or the sole strategy of economic pressure. Because North Korea is continuously improving its smuggling networks, sanctions are losing power and must now be "coupled with other tools" (Kleine-Ahlbrandt). In the US, there are structural challenges on top of the global tensions; while the President can negotiate directly with North Korea, any lasting agreement requires unprecedented cooperation with Congress (Schiffer).

However, this diplomatic stalemate introduces an opportunity to redesign current global strategy. Instead of immediate denuclearization, experts suggest world leaders transition toward more cooperative risk management. There is an opportunity in "military-to-civilian conversion," where the US and South Korea help transition North Korea's nuclear programs into

internationally monitored civilian energy projects, reducing immediate military risks and also building trust (Hecker et al.). Furthermore, the international community can address the collateral damage of the past two decades. Separating humanitarian issues from nuclear negotiations and modifying sanctions to guarantee uninterrupted delivery of aid will save countless vulnerable lives ("Humanitarian Impact"). If leaders fail to embrace new cohesive strategies, the world will waste another decade trapped in a cycle of useless, harmful sanctions and escalating nuclear danger (Moon and Park).

Works Cited

- Cha, Victor, and Ellen Kim. "Russia's Veto: Dismembering the UN Sanctions Regime on North Korea." *Center for Strategic and International Studies*, 29 Mar. 2024, www.csis.org/analysis/russias-veto-dismembering-un-sanctions-regime-north-korea. Accessed 30 Apr. 2026.
- Choe, Sang-Hun. "North Korea Says It's Building a Nuclear-Powered Submarine." *The New York Times*, 8 Mar. 2025, www.nytimes.com/2025/03/08/world/asia/north-korea-nuclear-powered-submarine.html?searchResultPosition=10. Accessed 12 Mar. 2026.
- "Clinton Adviser Says North Korea Is Advancing Its Nuclear Program." *New York Times*, www.nytimes.com/1999/03/12/world/clinton-adviser-says-north-korea-is-advancing-its-nuclear-program.html. Accessed 8 Mar. 2026.
- "Clinton Approves a Plan to Give Aid to North Koreans." *New York Times*, www.nytimes.com/1994/10/19/world/clinton-approves-a-plan-to-give-aid-to-north-koreans.html. Accessed 8 Mar. 2026.
- "Fact Sheet on DPRK Nuclear Safeguards." *International Atomic Energy Agency*, www.iaea.org/newscenter/focus/dprk/fact-sheet-on-dprk-nuclear-safeguards. Accessed 27 Feb. 2026.
- Hecker, Siegfried S., et al. "A Comprehensive History of North Korea's Nuclear Program." *Stanford Center for International Security and Cooperation*, May 2018, cisac.fsi.stanford.edu/content/cisac-north-korea. Accessed 12 Mar. 2026.

"The Humanitarian Impact of Sanctions on North Korea." *Korea Peace Now*,

koreapeacenow.org/resources/the-humanitarian-impact-of-sanctions-on-north-korea-2/.

Accessed 10 Apr. 2026.

Hussein, Fatima. "US sanctions North Korean bankers accused of laundering stolen

cryptocurrency." *APNews*, 4 Nov. 2025,

[apnews.com/article/trump-north-korea-crypto-nuclear-41f2f4e1c14ed0c81a41494c6c3afb](https://apnews.com/article/trump-north-korea-crypto-nuclear-41f2f4e1c14ed0c81a41494c6c3afb73)

73. Accessed 30 Apr. 2026.

Iqbal, Saira. "Effectiveness of United Nations Security Council Sanctions: A Case Study of

North Korea." *South Asian Studies*, pu.edu.pk/images/journal/csas/PDF/4_39_2_24.pdf.

Accessed 30 Apr. 2026.

"Kim Jong-un Open to Talks if U.S. Drops Demand to Denuclearize." *NYT*,

www.nytimes.com/2025/09/22/world/asia/kim-north-korea-trump-talks.html?searchResultPosition=3.

Kleine-Ahlbrandt, Stephanie. "Maximum Pressure Against North Korea." *38 North*, 7 Oct. 2019,

www.38north.org/2019/10/skleineahlbrandt100719/. Accessed 30 Apr. 2026.

"Korean War." *Britannica*, www.britannica.com/event/Korean-War. Accessed 8 Mar. 2026.

Lederer, Edith M. "China and Russia veto new UN sanctions on North Korea." *APNews*, 26 May

2022,

[apnews.com/article/politics-asia-united-states-north-korea-8f0e8d644856425b35d4e6072](https://apnews.com/article/politics-asia-united-states-north-korea-8f0e8d644856425b35d4e6072c363db7)

[c363db7](https://apnews.com/article/politics-asia-united-states-north-korea-8f0e8d644856425b35d4e6072c363db7). Accessed 30 Apr. 2026.

---. Russian veto effectively ends the UN panel that monitors North Korea nuclear sanctions. *PBS*

News, 28 Mar. 2024,

www.pbs.org/newshour/politics/russian-veto-effectively-ends-the-un-panel-that-monitors-north-korea-nuclear-sanctions. Accessed 12 Mar. 2026.

Moon, Katherine H.S., and Paul Park. "Are sanctions enough to deal with North Korea?"

Brookings, 2 Mar. 2016,

www.brookings.edu/articles/are-sanctions-enough-to-deal-with-north-korea/. Accessed 30 Apr. 2026.

"North Korea Says Kim's Relations With Trump 'Not Bad,' but Stands Firm on Nukes." *NYT*,

www.nytimes.com/2025/07/29/world/asia/north-korea-kim-trump.html?searchResultPosition=6.

Park, Kee B., et al. "The Human Costs of UN Sanctions and Funding Shortfalls for Humanitarian Aid in North Korea." *38 North*, 22 Aug. 2019,

www.38north.org/2019/08/parkkimjong082219/. Accessed 30 Apr. 2026.

Schiffer, Michael. "The Role and Authorities of the Executive Branch and Congress for the Implementation of a Potential North Korea Agreement." *The National Committee on North Korea*, June 2025, www.ncnk.org/node/2488. Accessed 30 Apr. 2026.

Snyder, Scott A. "The Economic Costs of North Korean Nuclear Development." *Council on Foreign Relations*, 25 Nov. 2013,

www.cfr.org/articles/economic-costs-north-korean-nuclear-development. Accessed 30 Apr. 2026.

"What to Know about Sanctions on North Korea." *Council on Foreign Relations*, 23 July 2022,

www.cfr.org/backgrounders/north-korea-sanctions-un-nuclear-weapons. Accessed 30 Apr. 2026.